

DO YOU NEED THE VACCINE?

6 points to consider before you go in for a jab...

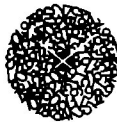
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It's official: there's likely to be far fewer deaths from the H1N1 virus than was initially believed. So should you bother?



TIME FACTOR:

To be effective, the vaccine has to be given before a flu 'season'. India is too late, even if it starts in February.



SAFETY FIRST:

India has little experience in flu vaccines. Plus it is being fast-tracked. Will the speed of manufacturing sacrifice quality?



MATCH MAKING:

Flu virus mutates. So vaccines are made by guessing at strains likely to appear next season. Effective only if the match is good.



WAVE THEORY:

Constant mutations often do not allow vaccines to provide immunity and protection during later waves.



SIDE EFFECTS:

In the past, there've been instances of death and debilitating diseases as the side effect of a new vaccine.



VERDICT: Go slow.

Meantime, as reports of a public backlash against the pandemic vaccine in the West circulate, a new debate emerges in India: do we need a vaccine, after all? And will it really protect us?

"The flu is past its prime and you want to give the vaccine now?" asks an angry Dr Madhav G. Deo. When the man who brewed the first anti-leprosy vaccine in India gets agitated, it's time to sit up and take note. Throughout the flu odyssey, Deo has been trying to make sense of the unconventional virus. But never in his life has he felt so frustrated—not while teaching pathology at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences



PARENTS WITH A CHILD SUSPECTED TO BE SICK WITH SWINE FLU AT A DELHI HOSPITAL

(AIIMS), not as the chief of the Cancer Research Institute, not in his efforts to disseminate cutting-edge knowledge to rural students. He gets irritated when the vaccine is projected as a panacea for taming the novel H1N1, feels let down when the Government listens to a cacophony of messages and announces ad hoc policies, and gets scared at the thought that India may have missed a "unique opportunity" to understand a pandemic threat, let alone to develop an effective treatment.

With 28,251 cases and a death toll of 1,136 so far, India has not seen a raging pandemic spread compared to the